

Design Project Checklist

Keep every design project on track from kickoff to delivery, with nothing forgotten and no scope quietly creeping.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Freelance designers and small studios juggling more than one client at a time, who need a repeatable way to keep projects from slipping through the cracks.

HOW TO USE IT

Copy this checklist into a new tracker for every project, or print one per job. Check items off as you go — don't move a project to the next phase until its section is complete.

1. KICKOFF

- ☐ Brief or discovery questionnaire completed and signed off by the client.
- ☐ Scope, timeline, and price are confirmed in writing — not just discussed verbally.
- ☐ Deposit or first payment received before design work begins.
- ☐ Number of revision rounds included is stated clearly, in the contract or proposal.

2. IN PROGRESS

- ☐ Concepts presented match what was actually agreed in the brief — not a personal tangent.
- ☐ Client feedback is captured in writing, even if it was given verbally or by voice note.
- ☐ Out-of-scope requests are flagged to the client immediately, not absorbed silently.
"Sure, I'll just add that" is how projects lose money.
- ☐ Files are backed up somewhere outside your one laptop.

3. REVIEW & APPROVAL

- ☐ Final design has been proofread by someone other than you — spelling, contact details, dates.
- ☐ Client has given explicit written approval, not just gone quiet.
- ☐ Any last-minute changes are logged, so scope creep is visible if it happens.

4. DELIVERY

- ☐ Final invoice sent and payment terms confirmed before final files are released.
- ☐ Files delivered in every format the client actually needs (print-ready, web, editable source).

- [] Files are named and organized so the client can find what they need in a year, without you.
- [] A copy of the final files and the signed brief is archived in your own project records.

5. AFTER DELIVERY

- [] Client is asked for a testimonial or referral while the work is still fresh.
- [] Project is added to your portfolio, if the client agrees.
- [] Any usage rights or licensing terms are documented, in case the client resells or reprints later.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most disputes with clients don't happen because the design was bad — they happen because scope, revisions, or payment terms were never written down anywhere. This checklist exists to make sure they always are.

NEXT STEPS

A checklist doesn't replace good client communication — but it catches the things good communication forgets when you're mid-project and juggling three other clients at once. Keep one running per job.